

**ADVANCING THE FRONTIERS OF POSSIBILITIES FOR SAFE, SECURED, AND
PROSPEROUS OYO STATE THROUGH CITIZEN'S ACTIVE PARTICIPATION IN
GOVERNANCE PROCESSES.**

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Abstract

This essay focuses on the importance of citizens' participation in governance processes. It explains what citizen participation is all about, the value of citizen participation in a state, and the various means by which citizen participation will influence a safe, secure and prosperous state.

Advancing the Frontiers of Possibilities for a Safe, Secured, and Prosperous Oyo State through Citizen's Active Participation in Governance Processes.

Citizens' involvement in governance processes has a significant impact on the swift growth of every developed state. The collective actions of their citizens in the political, social, and economical activities is one the major factor to their growth. On the contrary, many developing states are sluggishly growing because of the negative effect of a lack of citizen active participation in governance processes.

In recent years, citizens' active involvement in governance is believed to be a duty of citizens in every state because of its significant benefit. Citizens' participation refers to the involvement of the public in decision-making by governments. It can also be explained as the active participation of citizens in the society, which includes all forms of participation like political, social, cultural, or economic, as well as a combination of them.

The value of citizen participation is that it enables people to feel a sense of commitment to their neighborhood and are actively involved in activities to improve the quality of life there. In Oyo state, one of the most important factors in expanding the horizons of possibilities for a prosperous, safe, and secure state is citizens' engagement in governance processes. Thus, in this essay, I will discuss the various means by which citizens' engagement in the governance process can influence a safe, secure, and prosperous Oyo state.

One of the means citizens' active engagements in governance processes can influence a prosperous, safe, and secure State is by being security conscious. Security consciousness is about being in the state of noticing discrepancies in situations of our surroundings. It involves being vigilant, reporting suspicious activity to necessary authorities, helping others in security need, assisting local authorities in strengthening environmental security, among others. The benefit of this is that it influences security in the state.

Another means by which citizens' active engagement in governance processes can influence a prosperous, safe, and secure State is by keeping the environment safe and healthy. Environmental factors like erosions, dirty environment, pollution, among others are major problems affecting the State. However, citizens can directly correct this if necessary actions are taken to curb those issues. The importance of this is that it creates a favorable environment for peaceful, healthy, and safe living.

Basic infrastructure development is another means citizen participation in governance processes can influence a prosperous, safe, and secure State. Citizens can also play important role in the provision of basic amenities like constructing of drainage system in front of the building, provision of a wastebasket to store their waste, and so on. However, citizens' disinterest toward the important aspect of their environmental growth has been one of the major problems affecting developing states.

In the book *"Politics in Nigeria (2022),"* I cited some examples of *"how people build houses but they can't construct proper drainage in front of the building, some will even extend their building to the length where drainage should be. It is in this same environment you'll see people extending their buildings on major roads."* These few examples are the common abnormality affecting many developing states. However, all of these can be corrected by the collective actions of the citizens. The value of these is that they improve the better living of people in the community, reduces the burden on the government, and give the government the morale to be actively involved in the developmental process.

Another means by which citizens' engagement in governance processes can influence a prosperous, safe, and secure State is by participating in political and electoral processes. Citizens' engagement in the political and electoral processes is an important aspect in every state because the government is made possible through it. Some examples of citizen participation in political and the electoral process include voting in elections, running for electoral offices, voluntarily helping in electoral processes, petitioning, advocating for good governance, following up on budget allocated to their respective communities, shunning all forms of electoral rigging and manipulation, political and electoral education, and so on. When all these responsibilities are being carried out by citizens, the direct effect on governance is that it encourage the public to have meaningful input into the decision-making process.

Finally, citizens' active engagement in governance processes can influence a prosperous, safe, and secure State through citizens' education. Many citizens involve themselves in unlawful activities, while some other citizens avoided their responsibility in the state, and some citizens have no idea about what government is all about. However, the importance of citizens' education is that it solves issues like these.

Citizenship education is a socialization process whereby an individual will learn civic knowledge, skills and values upheld by the society, through formal, non-formal and informal

curriculum, and social participation and engagements. Citizen education, which is also known as civic education encompassing of four main aspects; They include *political knowledge*, *normative values*, *individualistic civic behavior*, and *communal civic behavior*. The values of Citizenship education is that it gives people the knowledge and skills to understand, challenge and engage with democratic society including politics, the media, civil society, the economy and the law.

I discussed the various means by which citizens' engagement in the governance process can influence a safe, secure, and prosperous Oyo state. Therefore, to conclude my points in this essay, I'll strongly believe that the major missing link in the Oyo State administration led by the amiable Governor, Mr. Seyi Makinde is citizens' active participation in the government's processes.

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